

The root directory is the highest level or the very top folder in a hierarchy. Think of a file system like an upside-down tree: the root is the starting point from which all other branches (folders and files) grow.

Depending on the context, "root directory" usually means one of two things:

1. The Operating System Root

This is the absolute top level of your computer's entire storage drive. You cannot go any higher than this.

- **Linux/macOS:** The root directory is represented by a single forward slash (/). Every file on the entire computer lives somewhere inside /.
- **Windows:** The root directory is usually your main drive letter, like C:\.

2. The Project Root

When developers talk about putting a file like `CLAUDE.md` or `package.json` in the "root directory," they mean the **top-level folder of that specific project**, not the entire computer. If you have a folder called `my-app` that contains `src/`, `node_modules/`, and `public/`, then `my-app` is your project's root directory. It is the starting folder where the project itself begins.